



MOOD INDIGO

A CHILD plays Lord Shiva, deep blue skin included, at the annual Pushkar Fair in Rajasthan. Pushkar, site of the only major Brahma temple in India, is built around a sacred lake and hosts the country's largest cattle fair every winter.

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In a joint Army and Indian Air Force operation on October 30, three An-32 medium-range transport aircraft from the Chandigarh-based 48 squadron quietly airdropped 96 Army paratroopers from a height of 10,000 ft over Nyoma airfield in Ladakh. This was the world's highest static line (where the parachute opens on exit) military group jump. The airdrop, carried out just 20 km from the Line of Actual Control (LAC) with China in temperatures of 10 degrees Celsius below zero, is part of an effort to enhance military preparedness on the border. Nyoma airfield, which is situated at an altitude of 15,000 ft, was reactivated in September this year. It is the third airfield in Ladakh after Daulat Beg Oldi and Chushul to be recommissioned over the past year to fly fixed-wing aircraft for resupplying the Army's forward posts. In the past, only helicopters have been landing at Nyoma. No doubt, this is more evidence of the Indian military's moves to counter China's growing military infrastructure on the border.

by Sandeep Unnithan



THREE AN-32 TRANSPORT AIRCRAFT DROPPED PARATROOPERS IN LADAKH, 20 KM FROM THE LAC WITH CHINA.